

ISTQB FOUNDATION MASTERCLASS

Flash Cards

30 exam-ready question and answer cards, grouped by syllabus chapter.

How to Use These Flash Cards

Cover the Answer column, read the Term or Question, and say the answer aloud before revealing it. Cards are grouped by the six chapters of the ISTQB Certified Tester Foundation Level (CTFL) syllabus. Aim to recall each card correctly on three separate days before the exam.

Chapter 1 — Fundamentals of Testing

Term / Question	Answer
What is a defect (bug)?	A flaw in a component or system that can cause it to fail to perform its required function.
Error vs defect vs failure?	An error (mistake) by a person causes a defect (fault) in code; a defect, when executed, may cause a failure (wrong external behaviour).
What is the purpose of testing?	To evaluate quality and reduce the risk of failure in operation; testing gives information for decisions, it does not "prove" correctness.
"Testing shows the presence of defects, not their absence" means?	Testing can reveal defects but can never prove there are none; passing tests do not guarantee a defect-free product.
What is exhaustive testing?	Testing every input and precondition combination. It is impossible except for trivial cases, so we use techniques and risk to focus effort.
What does the defect clustering principle state?	A small number of modules usually contain most of the defects (aligned with the Pareto principle).

Chapter 2 — Testing Throughout the SDLC

Term / Question	Answer
Name the four test levels.	Component (unit), Integration, System, and Acceptance testing.
What is component testing?	Testing individual components or units in isolation, usually by developers, often with stubs and drivers.
What is acceptance testing?	Validating readiness for use against user needs. Forms include UAT, operational, contractual/regulatory, alpha and beta testing.

Term / Question	Answer
Name the four main test types.	Functional, Non-functional, White-box (structural), and Change-related (confirmation and regression) testing.
Confirmation vs regression testing?	Confirmation re-tests a fixed defect to check it is resolved; regression checks that a change has not broken previously working areas.
What is shift-left?	An approach that performs testing and quality activities earlier in the lifecycle to find defects sooner and cheaper.

Chapter 3 — Static Testing

Term / Question	Answer
Static vs dynamic testing?	Static testing examines work products without executing code (reviews, static analysis); dynamic testing runs the software.
Name the review types by formality.	Informal review, walkthrough, technical review, and inspection (least to most formal).
Name the key review roles.	Manager, Author, Moderator (facilitator), Scribe (recorder), Reviewer, and Review leader.
A key benefit of static testing?	Finds defects early and cheaply, including some (e.g. requirement ambiguities) that dynamic testing cannot detect.

Chapter 4 — Test Techniques

Term / Question	Answer
Black-box vs white-box techniques?	Black-box derives tests from specifications/behaviour; white-box derives them from the internal structure/code.
What is equivalence partitioning?	Dividing inputs into partitions expected to be treated the same, then testing one value per partition (valid and invalid).
What is boundary value analysis?	Testing at the edges of partitions, where defects cluster (minimum, maximum and just inside/outside the boundaries).
When are decision tables useful?	When behaviour depends on combinations of conditions; each column is a rule combining conditions and actions.
What is state transition testing?	Testing valid and invalid transitions between the states of a system, based on a state diagram or table.
What is experience-based testing?	Techniques using tester knowledge and intuition: error guessing, exploratory testing and checklist-based testing.

Chapter 5 — Managing the Test Activities

Term / Question	Answer
What is in a test plan?	Scope, objectives, approach, resources, schedule, entry/exit criteria and risks for the test activities.
Entry vs exit criteria?	Entry (definition of ready) must be met to start an activity; exit (definition of done) must be met to consider it complete.
What is a product (quality) risk?	A risk that the product may fail to satisfy stakeholders (e.g. a defect); addressed by test design and execution.

Term / Question	Answer
What is risk-based testing?	Prioritising test effort by risk level (likelihood x impact), testing the highest-risk areas first and most thoroughly.
What does a defect report contain?	Unique ID, summary, steps to reproduce, expected vs actual result, severity, priority and status.
Severity vs priority?	Severity is the impact of the defect on the system; priority is the urgency with which it should be fixed.

Chapter 6 — Test Tools

Term / Question	Answer
A benefit and a risk of test automation?	Benefit: repeatable, fast regression runs. Risk: underestimating cost of maintaining tests and tools.
What is a test execution (unit test) tool?	A tool that runs tests automatically and compares actual with expected results (e.g. xUnit frameworks).

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Read the card, hide the answer, and answer aloud in a full sentence. Recalling actively (not just re-reading) is what moves knowledge into long-term memory before the exam.